POLITICS | Monologues

IDEAS OF INDIA: On Argumentative India and David and Goliath battles

ATISHI MARLENA *Minister of Education and PWD, Delhi*

BRAVING THE BIAS



BANDEEP SINGH

Delhi education minister Atishi Marlena said that while it is true India has grown economically, there are issues of concern on the health and education fronts. She said that India was slipping in the Human Development Index rankings, with healthcare and education still low on the priority list of the central government. She also talked about diversity being the biggest strength of the country, with the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) representing an important voice in this, as for a very long time, politics was considered the preserve of a few. But her most stinging criticism was reserved for the Centre's crackdown on the right to dissent and the use of central government agencies to target opposition parties and muzzle their voices. Marlena said she had lost track of the number of defamation cases the BJP had filed against her, adding that at last count, AAP, too, had some 186 cases against it. She also ridiculed the crackdown on corruption, raising the charges against the Adani group, and the lack of investigation into its shell companies abroad. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Indians have always had a voice, now it's time to raise it, challenge the system
- India's HDI index is 132 out of 191 states, most of our neighbours outrank us
- The use of central agencies to muzzle voices of dissent cannot go on

> **Today, central agencies are threatening the voices raised against the government. And that is the very core of the challenge to the idea of India. Our right to voice an opinion must be protected**
>
> ♦♦♦
>
> **Why is inequality rising in the country? It is because some people are favoured more than others... if India is to be a global superpower, we must question this kind of corruption**